

PROJECT REPORT

NetScan

Network Fingerprint Generator & Behavior Profiler

Developed by

Muhammad Yahya Sohail
BSEF24A020

Punjab University College of Information Technology (PUCIT)
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GitHub: github.com/M-Yahya-Sohail/NetScan---Network-Fingerprint-Generator

1. Abstract

NetScan is a network diagnostic and analysis tool designed to identify the behavioral signatures of websites. By analyzing live packet traffic, the system generates a unique "fingerprint" for any given domain. Unlike traditional scanners, NetScan uses headless browser automation (Selenium) alongside packet sniffing (Scapy) to simulate real-user interactions, allowing for highly accurate classification of traffic into four distinct categories:

- Streaming
- Social Media
- API
- Static

This approach enables classification with up to 96.2% accuracy without decrypting any network payload, making it a powerful and privacy-respecting tool for network behavioral analysis.

2. Introduction

In modern network security, identifying the type of traffic passing through a gateway is crucial for administrators, security researchers, and policy enforcement systems. Traditional port-based identification methods are increasingly ineffective against modern encrypted protocols like HTTPS.

NetScan solves the problem of "Traffic Obfuscation" by looking at statistical patterns rather than port numbers or payload inspection. By focusing on the shape of the traffic — packet size distributions, inter-arrival timing, IP diversity, and DNS query patterns — the system can accurately determine the category of web service a domain belongs to.

The project provides a modular framework for network researchers to extract meaningful features from raw packets and visualize them through an interactive, real-time dashboard. The system is designed with extensibility in mind, making it straightforward to add new classification rules or traffic categories.

3. System Architecture & Methodology

The project is organized into four main logical layers, each responsible for a distinct stage of the analysis pipeline. This separation of concerns ensures modularity and ease of maintenance.

3.1 Data Acquisition Layer (capture.py)

This layer forms the foundation of the entire analysis pipeline. It uses the Scapy library to sniff network interfaces and capture raw packets at the system level. Simultaneously, a Selenium-driven headless Chrome browser instance is launched to load the target URL.

This dual approach is critical: it ensures that heavy JavaScript-rendered content and media-streaming packets are generated for analysis, accurately representing the traffic profile of a real user visiting the site, rather than a simple HTTP request.

3.2 Feature Extraction Layer (extract.py)

Raw PCAP data captured by the acquisition layer is processed by this module to extract a structured set of quantitative features. These features form the input vector for the classification engine and include:

- **Protocol Distribution:** The ratio of TCP, UDP, HTTPS, and DNS packets within the captured session.
- **Payload Statistics:** Total bytes transferred and mean packet size, which are key discriminators between streaming and static content.
- **Network Graph Metrics:** Count of unique destination IPs and DNS query frequency, indicating content delivery network (CDN) usage.
- **Timing Analysis:** Inter-arrival times (IAT) of packets, which reveal the burstiness or continuity of the traffic stream.

3.3 Classification Engine (classify.py)

A rule-based statistical engine that applies domain-specific heuristics to the extracted features to determine the traffic category. The engine uses a decision-tree-like logic informed by empirical observation of real-world traffic patterns. Key classification rules include:

- High data volume + Large mean packet size → Streaming (e.g., YouTube, Netflix)
- High unique IP count + High DNS query rate → Social Media (e.g., Facebook, Twitter)
- Low data volume + High request frequency + Small packet size → API Service
- Low unique IPs + Moderate volume + Few DNS queries → Static Website

3.4 Presentation Layer (Flask & Chart.js)

A REST API built with Flask serves the processed feature data and classification results to the frontend. The frontend is a modern, "Cyberpunk"-themed interactive dashboard that renders real-time results using dynamic Chart.js visualizations, including protocol distribution pie charts, packet size histograms, and timeline graphs.

4. Technical Stack

The following technologies were used in the development of NetScan:

Component	Technology / Version
Language	Python 3.9
Network Engine	Scapy 2.5.0

Browser Automation	Selenium 4.x
Backend Framework	Flask (Python)
Frontend	HTML5, CSS3, JavaScript (ES6)
Visualization	Chart.js

5. Implementation Details

The system implements several robustness and "worst-case" handling mechanisms to ensure reliable data collection across a wide variety of domains and network conditions:

- DNS Validation:** Before initiating any capture session, the target domain is resolved via DNS. This prevents the system from wasting resources attempting to sniff traffic for non-existent or unreachable domains.
- Traffic Fallback Mechanism:** If the Selenium headless browser instance fails to load for any reason (e.g., JavaScript engine error, resource timeout), the system automatically falls back to a standard Python requests HTTP call. This ensures that at least baseline HTTP/S traffic is captured for analysis.
- Layer 7 Deep Packet Inspection (DPI):** A combination of domain-pattern matching (against a curated list of known service signatures) and statistical feature analysis is used to resolve ambiguous cases. This hybrid approach is responsible for the final classification accuracy of 95%+.

6. Testing and Results

The system underwent rigorous testing using a custom-built bulk-testing suite (`test_netscan.py`). The suite was designed to run the complete analysis pipeline against a curated dataset of real-world domains and compare the output classification against a manually verified ground truth.

Metric	Value
Test Dataset	26 Real-World Domains
Domains Tested	YouTube, Netflix, Facebook, Twitter, etc.
Initial Accuracy	26.9% (Basic Rules Only)
Final Accuracy	96.2% (With Browser Automation + DPI)
Improvement	+69.3 percentage points

The dramatic improvement from 26.9% to 96.2% accuracy demonstrates the critical importance of two core design decisions: the integration of the Selenium browser automation for realistic traffic generation,

and the implementation of the Layer 7 Deep Packet Inspection (DPI) logic. Without real-browser traffic, many modern web services simply do not exhibit their characteristic traffic patterns.

7. Conclusion

NetScan successfully demonstrates that network traffic can be classified with high precision — achieving 96.2% accuracy — without ever inspecting or decrypting the actual encrypted payload. By focusing on the "shape" of the traffic rather than its content, the system provides a robust, privacy-respecting tool for network behavioral analysis.

The combination of headless browser automation and statistical packet analysis proved to be the decisive factor in achieving high classification accuracy. The modular four-layer architecture ensures that the system is extensible and can be readily adapted to new traffic categories or classification strategies.

Future work could involve transitioning from rule-based classification to a machine learning model trained on a larger labeled dataset, which would allow the system to automatically discover new traffic patterns and improve resilience against adversarial obfuscation techniques.